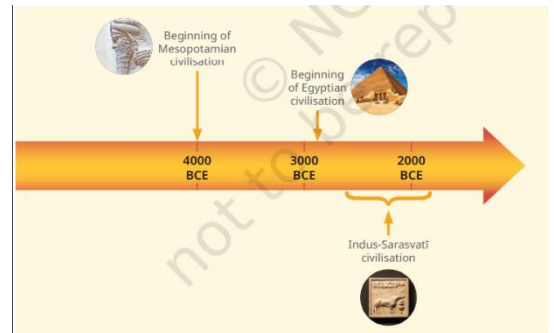


Chapter – 6: The Beginnings of Indian Civilisation

The most ancient civilisation of India, known variously as the Harappan, Indus or Indus-Sarasvatī Civilisation, was indeed remarkable in many ways. ... [It showed how] a well-balanced community lives — in which the differences between the rich and the poor are not glaring. ... In essence, the Harappan societal scenario was not that of 'exploitation', but of mutual 'accommodation'. — B.B. Lal

What is a Civilisation?

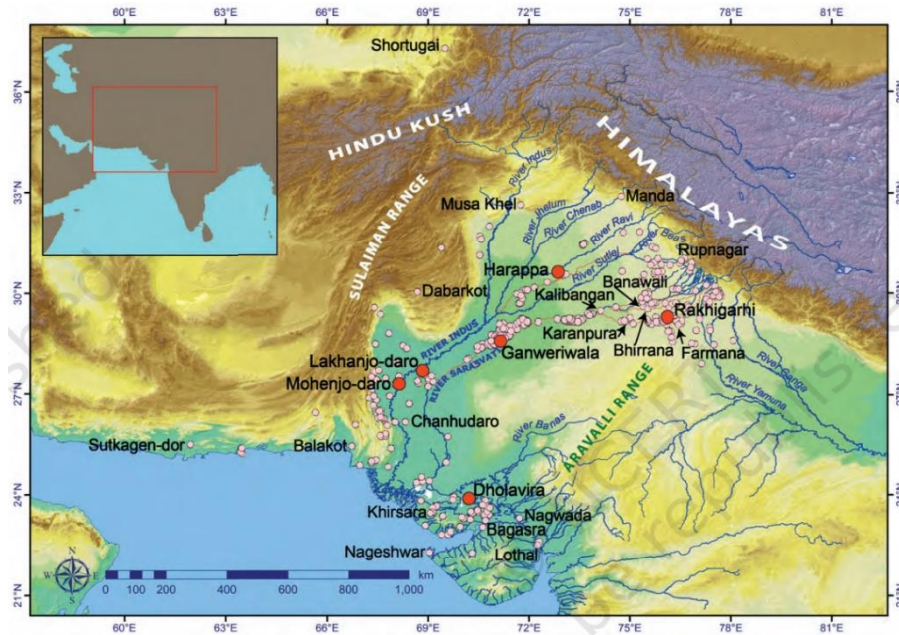
- Ch. 4 end – 1st human grp. – settle down – practice agriculture, develop technologies – construction, **metallurgy**, transport – moving toward 'civilisation'
- In general – this term – adv. stage – human societies
- Precisely – civilisation – required characteristics –
 - **Govt. or administration** – manage – complex society and activities
 - **Urbanism** – town-planning, growth of cities – management – water and drainage system
 - **Crafts** – variety – management – raw materials – stone and metal – production – finished goods – ornaments and tools
 - **Trade** – internal OR external – exchange – all kinds of goods
 - **Writing** – some form – keep records – communicate
 - **Cultural ideas** – life and world – art, architecture, literature, oral traditions, social customs
 - **Agriculture** – enough – feed – villages and cities
- Easy to notice – all characteristics – present – most societies – world today – BUT – when did it started
- Civilisation – start – diff. times – diff. parts of world
- Mesopotamia – modern Iraq and Syria – around 6000 yrs. ago
- Ancient Egypt – few centuries later
- Humanity – would not have reached its present age – without contributions and advances – ancient civilisations
- This chapter – Indian subcontinent – northwest region – story begins



From Village to City?

- Vast plains – Punjab (currently divided in India and Pakistan) – Sindh (currently in Pakistan) – watered by – Indus River and its **tributaries**
- These plains – very fertile – favourable to agriculture
- Little further east – few millenniums ago – another river – Sarasvati – flow from foothills of Himalayas through – Haryana, Punjab, Rajasthan, Gujarat
- This region – 3500 BCE – villages turn to towns – trade and exchange increase – towns turn to cities – 2600 BCE
- Archaeologists – diff. names – Indus, Harappan, Indus-Sarasvati, Sindhu-Sarasvati
- Habitants – Harappan – this civilisation – one of the oldest
- This development – 1st urbanization of India
- Harappan city – modern state / region –
 - Dholavira – Punjab
 - Harappa – Gujarat

- Kalibangan – Sindh
- Mohenjo-daro – Haryana
- Rakhigarhi - Rajasthan



The Sarasvati River

- Map – Indus (Sindhu) – five main tributaries – imp. cities – along these rivers – Mohenjo-daro, Harappa
- Many sites – along Sarasvati River – today – Ghaggar (India) and Hakra (Pakistan) – this river – seasonal – flows in rainy season
- This river – 1st mentioned – Rig Veda – ancient collection of prayers
- Sarasvati – worshipped – Goddess and River – flow – mountain to sea
- Later texts – river – drying up – eventually disappearing

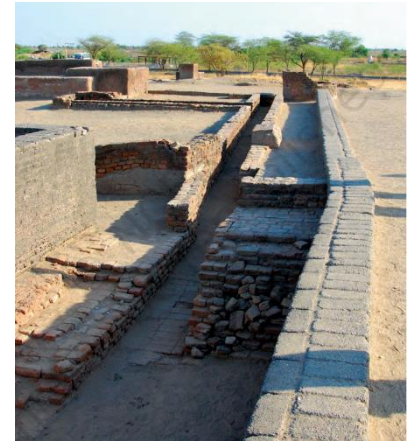
Town-Planning

- Harappa, Mohenjo-daro – (currently in Pakistan) – 1st cities – discovered – 1924
- Several sites – Indus plains – civilisation called – Indus Valley Civilisation
- Later – other major cities – Dholavira (Gujarat), Rakhigarhi (Haryana), Ganweriwala (Cholisthan Desert, Pakistan), 100s of smaller cities (Lothal, Gujarat)
- Such discoveries – continue even today
- Sarasvati basin – 2 major cities – Rakhigarhi, Ganweriwala – many smaller ones – Farmana (Haryana), Kalibangan (Rajasthan) – few towns – Bhirrana, Banawali (Haryana)
- Map – makes clear – high density of sites – this region
- Larger Harappan cities – built – precise plans
- Wide streets – oriented to cardinal dir.
- Most cities – surrounded – **fortifications** – 2 distinct parts –
 - Upper town – local **elites** lived
 - Lower town – common people lived
- Large buildings – collective purposes – warehouses – goods to be stored
- Individual houses – various sizes – streets and smaller lanes
- Quality of construction – same – small and big houses – generally – made of bricks
- Purpose – some structures – still a debate – example – Great Bath
- Great Bath – small – BUT – elaborate tank – 12 x 7 meters – carefully laid-out bricks – waterproofing materials – natural bitumen – form of tar

- This tank – surrounded by – small rooms – one room – well – one corner – drain – empty the tank
- Purpose – this structure – archaeologists – diff. interpretations
 - Public bath for people
 - Bath for royal family only
 - Tank for religious rituals
- 1st interpretation – ruled out – most houses – individual bathrooms

Water Management

- Harappans – much importance – water management, cleanliness
- Often – separate areas – bathing – in homes – connected to larger drains – network – below the streets – took – waste water away
- Mohenjo-daro – water drawn from – 100s of wells – made of bricks
- Other regions – may be from ponds, nearby streams, human-made **reservoirs**
- Dholavira – Kutch, Gujarat – largest reservoir – 73 meters long
- Dholavira – 6 reservoirs – made of stone – cut into rocks – connected – underground drains – efficient water harvesting
- No. of workers – required – build these systems – very large – reservoirs – cleaned regularly – managed by – city's administrations



What did Harappans Eat?

- Harappans – settlements – along the banks – large or small rivers
- Logical choice – easy access to water – agriculture – soil – enriched by rivers
- Archaeological findings – Harappans grew cereals – barley, wheat, millets, rice, **pulses**, vegetables
- 1st in Eurasia – grow cotton – weave clothes
- Developed farming tools – plough, etc. – even used today
- Intense agriculture – managed by – 100s of rural sites
- Those times – cities – survived only – agricultural produce reaches on a daily basis
- Harappans – domesticated – no. of animals – meat consumptions – fishing – rivers and seas
- Large no. – fish and animal bones – found during excavations
- Harappan cooking pots – expected – dairy products – unexpected – turmeric, ginger, banana
- Their diet – quite diverse

A Brisk Trade

- Harappans – active trade – within their civilisation – BUT ALSO – other civilisations
- **Export** – ornaments, timber, obj. of daily use, gold, cotton, some food items
- Most favored ornaments – beads of carnelian – reddish semiprecious stone
- Harappan craftspeople – special technique – drill them – pass string – decorate them
- Conch shells – turned to – shell bangles – sophisticated techniques – shell – hard material
- **Import** – not clear – probably copper – not so common here
- Harappans – mastered the art – working copper – soft metal
- Add tin to copper – resulting metal – bronze – used for – tools, pots, pans, figurines
- For this trade – land routes and rivers – ALSO – sea – more distant destinations

- Many Harappan settlements – located – coastal regions – Gujarat, Sindh
- Lothal – small settlement – Gujarat – huge basin – 217 m length – 36 m width
- This basin – must by dockyard – receive and send boats – transport of goods
- Such trade – traders – identify goods and themselves – chief purpose – 1000s of small seals
- These seals – generally – made of steatite – soft stone – hardened on heating
- Measure – few centimetre – generally depict – animal figures – AND – few symbols – part of writing system
- This system – AND – meaning of animals – not yet understood



The End or a New Beginning?

- Around 1900 BCE – Sindhu-Sarasvati civilisation – so much achievements – YET – fell apart
- Cities – abandoned – one by one – somebody still left – moved to villages – changed env.
- Earlier govt. – no longer existed
- Harappans – scattered – 100s of small rural settlements
- Cause of decline – many factors –
 - Long back – invasions of warfare – destroyed cities – BUT – no traces – Harappans – no army or weapons – rel. peaceful civilisation
 - Currently – 2 factors – agreed upon –
 - Climatic change – 2200 BCE onward – reduced rainfall – drier phase – agriculture more difficult – reduced food supply
 - Sarasvati river – dried up – central basin – cities – Kalibangan or Banawali – abandoned
 - May be other factors – BUT – above 2 – remind us – climate, env. – very imp.
- Cities – disappeared – BUT – Harappan culture, technology – survived – passed on – next phase – Indian civilisation